

Ārya-saptaśatikā-nāma-prajñāpāramitā-mahāyāna-sūtra · Toh 24 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་ཤེས་རབ་ཀྱི་རལ་ཏུ་ཕྱུ་པ་བདུ་བར་སྒྲུ་ཞེས་བུ་ཐག་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མཛན་

In the language of India:
 Ārya-saptaśatikā-nāma-prajñāpāramitā-mahāyāna-sūtra. In the language of
 Tibet: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called the Perfection of Wisdom in Seven
 Hundred Lines. First fascicle. Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Then Mañjuśrī in his youthful form set out from his own dwelling at the hour of dawn, in order to behold the Tathāgata, to pay homage to him, and to attend upon him. He went to the place where the gate of the Tathāgata's palace hall was, arrived there, and stood outside the gate of the palace hall.

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra likewise set out from his own dwelling in order to behold the Blessed One, to pay homage to him, and to attend upon him, and went to the place where the Tathāgata's palace hall was.

Then the venerable Pūrṇa Maitrāyaṇīputra, the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana, the venerable Mahākāśyapa, the venerable Mahākātyāyana, the venerable Mahākauṣṭhila, and all the others — all those great śrāvakas — set out each from his own dwelling, went to the place where the Blessed One's palace hall was, arrived there, and took up their positions to one side.

Then the Blessed One, knowing that the great śrāvakas had come, arrived, and assembled, emerged from his own palace hall and sat down on a seat spread outside the palace hall to one side.

Having sat down, the Blessed One, knowing full well, spoke to the venerable Śāradvatīputra: "Śāradvatīputra, why have you come at this early hour and are standing at the gate of the Tathāgata's palace hall?"

When this was said, the venerable Śāradvatīputra replied to the Blessed One as follows: "Blessed One, it was Mañjuśrī in his youthful form who arrived first of all at the gate of the Tathāgata's palace hall. As for myself, Blessed One, I came afterward in order to behold the Blessed One."

Then the Blessed One, knowing full well, spoke to Mañjuśrī in his youthful form: "Mañjuśrī, is it true that you, first of all, came to stand at the gate of the Tathāgata's palace hall in order to behold the Tathāgata, to pay homage to him, and to attend upon him?"

When this was said, Mañjuśrī in his youthful form replied to the Blessed One as follows: "Blessed One, it is so. Sugata, it is so. I set out first of all from my own dwelling in order to behold the Tathāgata, to pay homage to him, and to attend upon him. I went to the place where the Tathāgata's palace hall was and took up a position to one side. And why? Blessed One, it is because I have not grown weary of beholding the Tathāgata, paying homage to him, and attending upon him. Blessed One, my coming in order to behold the Tathāgata, to pay homage to him, and to attend upon him is also for the sake of all sentient beings.

"Blessed One, just as I behold the Tathāgata, just as I pay homage, and just as I attend upon him, let all beings behold the Tathāgata in that same way, pay homage in that same way, and attend upon him in that same way. For in that

manner, from the act of beholding the Tathāgata through to the act of attending upon him, it shall be so. Blessed One, it is for the sake of all sentient beings that I behold the Tathāgata."

The Blessed One then spoke: "Mañjuśrī, how does one behold the Tathāgata?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "One beholds the Tathāgata in the manner of non-apprehension — in the aspect of suchness and in the aspect of non-conceptuality. Likewise, one beholds the Tathāgata in the aspect of non-arising, and on through to the aspect of the absence of any thing whatsoever. In suchness there is no arising from anywhere — and so one beholds the Tathāgata. Suchness neither arises nor perishes — and so one beholds the Tathāgata. Suchness does not abide in any object nor does it abide in any direction — and so one beholds the Tathāgata. Suchness does not belong to the past, nor to the future, nor to the present — and so one beholds the Tathāgata. Suchness is not differentiated by duality, nor is it differentiated by non-duality — and so one beholds the Tathāgata. Suchness does not become defiled, nor does it become purified — and so one beholds the Tathāgata. Suchness is without arising and without cessation — and so one beholds the Tathāgata. In this way, beholding, paying homage to, and attending upon the Tathāgata shall be so accomplished."

When Mañjuśrī had spoken thus, the Blessed One addressed Mañjuśrī in his youthful form with these words: "Mañjuśrī, when you behold in this way, what do you see?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, when I behold in this way, there is nothing whatsoever that I see. Blessed One, in just the same way, I do not see the arising of any phenomenon whatsoever, nor do I see its cessation."

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to Mañjuśrī in his youthful form: "Mañjuśrī, this beholding of the Tathāgata and this attending upon him in such a manner, and yet, while your great loving-kindness abides close to all sentient beings, there is in you not the slightest apprehension of sentient beings nor any clinging to them as sentient beings — and while you are engaged for the sake of leading all sentient beings to complete nirvāṇa, not the slightest clinging to sentient beings as sentient beings ever arises in you — and the fact that you have donned the armor for the sake of all sentient beings in the manner of non-apprehension, in the manner of the absence of any thing, and in the manner of the absence of despondency: this, indeed, is what makes your undertaking arduous."

When he had spoken thus, Mañjuśrī in his youthful form replied to the venerable Śāradvatīputra: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, it is exactly as you have said. I have donned this very armor for the sake of leading all sentient beings to complete nirvāṇa, and yet in me there is not the slightest apprehension of sentient beings nor any clinging to sentient beings. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, that armor was not donned by me with any thought such as 'I will deplete the realm of sentient beings' or 'I will make it empty.' Venerable Śāradvatīputra, consider this thoroughly: if in each and every buddha field there were as many blessed buddhas as there are grains of sand in the Gaṅgā, and each of those Tathāgatas were to teach the Dharma day and night continuously,

and were to remain for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the Gaṅgā — and if as many sentient beings as each of those blessed buddhas, the Tathāgatas, one by one, brought to discipline through each of their teachings of the Dharma were indeed brought to discipline — still, there would be no perceivable depletion or filling up of the realm of sentient beings. Why is that? Because sentient beings are empty of sentient beings, and sentient beings are not sentient beings. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, the realm of sentient beings is not perceived to be depleted or filled.

When this was said, the Venerable Śāradvatīputra spoke to the youthful Mañjuśrī as follows: "Mañjuśrī, if the realm of sentient beings is not perceived to be depleted or filled because sentient beings are empty of sentient beings and sentient beings are not sentient beings, then after fully and perfectly awakening to buddhahood, to whom does one teach the Dharma?"

When this was said, the youthful Mañjuśrī replied to the Venerable Śāradvatīputra: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, when sentient beings are utterly imperceptible, then who fully and perfectly awakens, and to whom is the Dharma to be taught? Why is that? Because, Venerable Śāradvatīputra, all phenomena are utterly imperceptible."

Then the Blessed One spoke to the youthful Mañjuśrī as follows: "Mañjuśrī, when all phenomena are utterly imperceptible, can anything still be designated as a sentient being? And further, Mañjuśrī, if someone were to ask you, 'How many sentient beings are there?' what would you say to them?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, to one who asked that question I would say: 'There are as many as the Dharma qualities of a buddha.'"

"Blessed One, and if someone were to ask, 'How vast is the extent of the realm of sentient beings?' to that question I would reply: 'As vast as the domain of a

buddha.'" "

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, if someone were to ask you, 'To what does the realm of sentient beings belong?' what would you say?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, to one who asked that question I would say: 'It belongs to the same category as the inconceivable realm of non-arising.'" "

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, if someone were to ask you, 'In what does the realm of sentient beings abide?' what would you say?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, to one who asked that question I would say: 'Whatever the realm of non-arising abides in, the realm of sentient beings abides in that as well.'" "

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, when you cultivate the Perfection of Wisdom, what do you rest in while cultivating it?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, when I cultivate the Perfection of Wisdom, I cultivate it without resting in anything." "

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, if one rests in nothing, what is there to cultivate with regard to the Perfection of Wisdom?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, not resting in anything whatsoever — that itself is the cultivation of the Perfection of Wisdom." "

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, when you cultivate the Perfection of Wisdom, do your roots of virtue increase or diminish?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, at that time there is nothing whatsoever that could cause my roots of virtue to increase or diminish." "

Mañjuśrī said: "Blessed One, if there were any phenomenon whatsoever that could increase or diminish, that would not be cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, I understand that whoever remains present for the sake of increasing or diminishing any phenomenon whatsoever — that is not cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom." "

Blessed One, whoever neither abandons the phenomena of ordinary beings nor takes up the phenomena of buddhas — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom. Why is that? Blessed One, it is because cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom means not resting in any phenomenon at all, since one does not fixate on any phenomenon to be abandoned or taken up." "

Blessed One, whoever does not approach saṃsāra as a fault, and does not approach nirvāṇa as a virtue — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom. Why is that? Blessed One, if saṃsāra itself is not seen, what need is there to speak of the faults of saṃsāra? And if nirvāṇa itself is not apprehended, what need is there to speak of the virtues of nirvāṇa? Thus, Blessed One, whoever has no taking up, grasping, or casting away with regard to any phenomenon whatsoever — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom.

Blessed One, whoever does not apprehend diminishment or increase in any phenomenon whatsoever — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom. Why is that? Blessed One, it is because in what is unborn there is no diminishment and no increase.

Blessed One, whoever cultivates in this way — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom.

Blessed One, whoever does not cause any phenomenon whatsoever to arise or cease — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, whoever does not cause any phenomenon whatsoever to diminish or expand — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, whoever cultivates in this way — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom.

Blessed One, furthermore, one does not aspire toward inconceivable phenomena, nor does one aspire toward inferior phenomena. Rather, Blessed One, the very object of aspiration and the aspirer thereof are both utterly absent — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, if one cultivates in this way, that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom.

Blessed One, cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom means not abiding in the view that these phenomena are supreme and those phenomena are inferior, and not apprehending those phenomena through which anything could become supreme or inferior. Thus a son of good family who strives in the yoga of cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom does not apprehend any phenomenon whatsoever.

Blessed One, cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom means not conceiving of any phenomenon as supreme or inferior. Why is that? Blessed One, it is because in what is unborn there is nothing whatsoever to be called supreme or inferior. In suchness, in the perfect limit, and throughout all phenomena, there is nothing supreme and nothing inferior. Blessed One, if one cultivates in this way, that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom."

When Mañjuśrī had spoken these words, the Blessed One declared to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, are not the phenomena of buddhas supreme?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, because they cannot be grasped, the phenomena of buddhas are supreme. Blessed One, has the Tathāgata awakened to perfect and complete buddhahood with respect to the emptiness of all phenomena?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, it is so. The Tathāgata has awakened to perfect and complete buddhahood with respect to the emptiness of all phenomena."

Mañjuśrī then said:

"Blessed One, is there anything that could be called supreme or inferior with regard to emptiness?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, excellent, excellent! Mañjuśrī, it is exactly so — just as you have said. Mañjuśrī, are not the phenomena of buddhas unsurpassable?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "It is indeed so, Blessed One: the phenomena of buddhas are unsurpassable. And why is that? Blessed One, because not even the slightest phenomenon is to be found in them, nor apprehended — for that reason, those phenomena of buddhas are unsurpassable. Furthermore, Blessed One, one who neither strives to achieve the phenomena of buddhas nor strives to abandon the phenomena of ordinary beings, who neither tames nor grasps at the phenomena of buddhas — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom. Furthermore, Blessed One, one who does not conceive of any phenomenon whatsoever, and who does not cognize anything — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom."

The Blessed One then declared: "Mañjuśrī, do you not conceive of the phenomena of buddhas?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, if I were to see the phenomena of buddhas as thoroughly established, then I would be conceiving of the phenomena of buddhas. Blessed One, cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom does not involve dwelling through conceptual thought with regard to any phenomenon whatsoever — thinking 'these are the phenomena of ordinary beings,' 'these are the phenomena of śrāvakas,' 'these are the phenomena of pratyekabuddhas,' or 'these are the phenomena of perfectly and completely awakened buddhas.' And why is that? Blessed One, a son of good family who

strives in the yoga of cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom does not apprehend even those very phenomena themselves — for the nature of reality of those phenomena that are described as phenomena of ordinary beings, or described as phenomena of those in training, or described as phenomena of those beyond training, or described as phenomena of pratyekabuddhas, or described as phenomena of perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, is a nature of reality that transcends all extremes, and so that phenomenon is neither apprehended nor rightly discerned. Blessed One, to cultivate in that way is to cultivate the Perfection of Wisdom.

"Furthermore, Blessed One, a son of good family who strives in the yoga of cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom does not conceive, from 'this is the desire realm,' 'this is the form realm,' 'this is the formless realm,' and so on, all the way to 'this is the dharmadhātu of cessation.' And why is that? Blessed One, because one sees absolutely no phenomenon as being the phenomenon that is cessation. Blessed One, to cultivate in that way is, I maintain, to cultivate the Perfection of Wisdom.

"Furthermore, Blessed One, one who does not regard any phenomenon whatsoever as beneficial or harmful — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom is neither producing the phenomena of buddhas nor cutting off the phenomena of ordinary beings. Blessed One, one who neither suppresses the phenomena of ordinary beings nor attains the phenomena of buddhas — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom."

When Mañjuśrī had spoken these words, the Blessed One declared to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, excellent, excellent! It is good that you have taught a profound Dharma such as this. Mañjuśrī, you have

set forth this seal in order that those on the bodhisattva vehicle who still hold to objects of reference may come to understand correctly and as things truly are. Mañjuśrī, those sons and daughters of good family who, upon hearing this teaching of the profound Perfection of Wisdom, feel no fear, no alarm, and no dismay — they have not served merely one buddha, nor have they cultivated roots of virtue under merely one buddha."

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the youthful Mañjuśrī said to him: "Blessed One, I am confident to teach the Perfection of Wisdom extensively."

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, do so with confidence."

Mañjuśrī then said: "Blessed One, not to perceive any phenomenon by which a thing abides, and equally not to perceive non-abiding — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom. Why so? Because all phenomena are not perceived on account of their non-abiding. Blessed One, not to dwell in proximity to anything on account of taking any phenomenon whatsoever as a superimposed object of reference — that is to be understood as cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom. Why so? Blessed One, it is because all phenomena are without any object of reference whatsoever. Blessed One, to cultivate in just that way is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom.

"Blessed One, furthermore, that cultivation in which one does not even conceive of the phenomena of buddhas as something to be realized — let alone, needless to say, the phenomena of pratyekabuddhas — and in which the phenomena of śrāvakas likewise are not realized — let alone, needless to say, the phenomena of ordinary beings — that is to be regarded as cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom.

"Blessed One, furthermore, that non-conceptual cultivation in which one does not conceive, even with respect to the inconceivable phenomena of buddhas, that 'the phenomena of buddhas are inconceivable' — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, this cultivation of the Perfection of Wisdom is to be regarded as the non-conceptual engagement with all phenomena on the part of great bodhisattvas, bodhisattvas of great heroic spirit.

"Blessed One, furthermore, that cultivation through which one sees all phenomena as phenomena of buddhas without there being any seeing, and sees all phenomena as inconceivable phenomena — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom. Those sons and daughters of good family who, upon hearing this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom, feel no fear, no alarm, and no dismay — they will have served many hundreds and thousands of buddhas.

"Blessed One, furthermore, not to perceive correctly any phenomenon whatsoever that belongs to defilement or to purification — that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, to cultivate in just that way is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom.

"Blessed One, this cultivation of the Perfection of Wisdom makes no distinction whatsoever between ordinary beings, śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and perfectly and completely awakened buddhas. Blessed One, that is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom."

Then the Blessed One declared to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, how many Tathāgatas have you served?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, as many as the minds of illusory beings and the mental states arisen from such minds that have ceased — that many. Blessed One, I have served that many Tathāgatas."

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, have you not fully entered into the phenomena of buddhas?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, is there anything whatsoever that can be apprehended as a phenomenon belonging to one who has fully entered into the phenomena of buddhas?"

The Blessed One declared:

"Mañjuśrī, then — in whom do those phenomena of buddhas exist?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, even for you there is no name for what is called 'the phenomena of buddhas,' let alone any apprehension of them. If they cannot be apprehended even here, how much less could they exist in others?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, have you attained non-attachment?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, I myself am nothing but non-attachment. How then could I attain non-attachment?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, are you seated at the seat of awakening?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "If the ultimate limit were firmly established, then even you, Blessed One, would not have entered the seat of awakening — so how could someone like me be there?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, whose expression is what is called 'the ultimate limit'?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, what is called 'the ultimate limit' is an expression belonging to the composite heap of personality."

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, thinking of what did you say that?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, that collection is non-existent. Because the composite heap of personality is not real, it neither changes nor is it free from change — and for that reason this collection is not the composite heap of personality."

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who hear this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom and have faith and are not frightened, not terrified, not dismayed — they are destined for awakening."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who hear this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom and have faith and are not frightened, not terrified, not dismayed — they have drawn near to awakening. And why? Because, Blessed One, the non-conceptual engagement with those very phenomena is itself supreme awakening."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who hear this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom and have faith and are not frightened, not terrified, not dismayed — I regard them as buddhas themselves. And why? Because, Blessed One, what is called 'buddha' is, in the ultimate sense, an expression signifying the absence of birth."

Then the sister Anupadadharminī addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who hear this Perfection of Wisdom and have faith and are not frightened, not terrified, not dismayed — they will not superimpose apprehension upon the phenomena of ordinary persons, nor upon the phenomena of śrāvakas, nor upon the phenomena of pratyekabuddhas, nor upon the phenomena of perfectly and fully awakened buddhas. And why? Because, Blessed One, all phenomena being non-existent, they are non-apprehended; and therefore there is no apprehension of them."

Then the Blessed One declared to the venerable Śāradvatīputra: "So it is, Śāradvatīputra, so it is. Sons and daughters of good family who hear this teaching of the profound Perfection of Wisdom and have faith and are not frightened, not terrified, not dismayed — they are destined for awakening. Śāradvatīputra, sons and daughters of good family who hear this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom and have faith, are not frightened, not terrified, not dismayed, and receive it with the crown of their head — know that they abide on the ground of irreversibility."

"Śāradvatīputra, those who hear this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom and have faith and are not frightened, not terrified, not dismayed — they shall become excellent benefactors, they shall become great benefactors, they shall

become supremely exalted benefactors. Śāradvatīputra, they shall become accomplished in moral discipline; they shall become the foremost among those endowed with moral discipline; they shall become supremely exalted among those endowed with moral discipline; and they shall find the path of the qualities of moral discipline. Śāradvatīputra, those who hear this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom and have faith and are not frightened, not terrified, not dismayed — they shall come to possess the supreme patience, the supreme diligence, the supreme meditative concentration, and the supreme wisdom that is without equal. Śāradvatīputra, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who hear this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom and have faith and are not frightened, not terrified, not dismayed — they shall come to possess, and continue until they attain, the primordial wisdom of omniscience endowed with the supreme of all aspects."

Then the Blessed One spoke further to the youthful Mañjuśrī, saying: "Mañjuśrī, what aim do you see that you wish to fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, complete, perfect awakening?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, if I were to enter into awakening, then in that case I would also be wishing to fully and perfectly awaken. Blessed One, I have no aspiration toward awakening. And why is that? Blessed One, that which is the youthful Mañjuśrī himself is awakening itself."

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Excellent, Mañjuśrī, excellent! You have well taught this profound point of profundity in just this way. For you have previously served the Victors and have long practiced the holy life of non-apprehension."

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, if I were to practice non-apprehension, that itself would constitute attaining something."

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, do you see these well-accomplished śrāvakas of mine?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, I do see them."

The Blessed One asked: "How do you see them, and in what manner?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, I see them in the way that they are not seen as ordinary persons, not seen as those in training, not seen as those beyond training — there is no seeing and there is no non-seeing. I see them in this way: not seen as many, not seen as few, not seen as tamed, not seen as untamed."

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, if you see the followers of the śrāvaka vehicle in that way, how do you see the followers of the vehicle of the fully and perfectly awakened buddhas?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, I do not perceive any phenomenon called 'bodhisattva.' I do not perceive any phenomenon called 'entering into awakening.' I do not perceive any phenomenon called 'practicing for the sake of awakening.' I do not perceive any phenomenon called 'fully and perfectly awakening.' Venerable Śāradvatīputra, I see the followers of the vehicle of the fully and perfectly awakened buddhas in just that way."

Śāradvatīputra said: "Mañjuśrī, how do you see the Tathāgata?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, let the great elephant be still. Let the great elephant not be disturbed."

When he had spoken these words, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said this to Mañjuśrī the youthful: "Mañjuśrī, the word 'buddha' — whose utterance is it a synonym for?"

Mañjuśrī said: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, the word 'self' — whose utterance is it a synonym for?"

Śāradvatīputra said: "Mañjuśrī, it is like this: the word 'self' is a synonym for the unborn."

Mañjuśrī said: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, just so. Just as the word 'self' is a synonym for the unborn, the word 'buddha' too is a synonym for that same thing. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, it is also like this: the word 'buddha' is a synonym for that which is without foundation. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, the word 'buddha' is difficult to know through words. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, if even a word is difficult to analyze as a word, what need is there to speak of the word 'buddha'? Venerable Śāradvatīputra, when one says 'the word "buddha" — whose utterance is it a synonym for,' this refers to something that is not truly established, not born, and not ceasing — something that does not possess any phenomenon whatsoever, that has no foundation of any kind, is inseparable from the foundationless, and is without foundation. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, it is like this: the word 'buddha' is a synonym for that.

"Venerable Śāradvatīputra, one who wishes to seek the Tathāgata should seek the self. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, the word 'self' is a synonym for the word 'buddha': just as what is called 'self' utterly does not exist and is not to be apprehended as an object, so too the buddha utterly does not exist and is not

to be apprehended as an object. Just as what is called 'self' cannot be expressed in words through any phenomenon whatsoever, so too the buddha cannot be expressed in words through any phenomenon whatsoever. That for which there is no enumeration — that is called a buddha. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, the foundational synonym of the word 'self' is not easy to know. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, likewise, this foundational synonym of the word 'buddha' is also not easy to know."

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Blessed One, Mañjuśrī the youthful does not teach in a manner appropriate for those who are at the beginning of their practice."

When this was said, Mañjuśrī the youthful spoke to the venerable Śāradvatīputra in these words: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, I do not teach such Dharma as would be understood even by one who has realized arhathood. Nor do I teach in such a way that it would be understood by just anyone. Why is that? Because awakening is not known by anyone, not fully cognized by anyone, not fully and completely realized by anyone — it has not been seen, not heard, not recalled, not produced, not obstructed, not spoken, and not taught. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, awakening is like this, and awakening is also not a thing. Why is that? Because there is nothing whatsoever that fully and completely awakens through awakening, and awakening itself does not fully and completely awaken through awakening."

Śāradvatīputra said: "Mañjuśrī, did the Blessed One fully and completely awaken to the dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, that is not so. Why? Because, venerable Śāradvatīputra, the dharmadhātu itself is the Blessed One."

"Venerable Śāradvatīputra, if the Blessed One were to have fully and completely awakened to the dharmadhātu, then that would also contradict the very realm that is free of arising. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, the dharmadhātu itself is awakening. Why is that? Because the dharmadhātu has no sentient beings. The expression 'all phenomena are without essential nature' is a synonym for awakening, and it falls within the category of the dharmadhātu. Why is that? Because all phenomena are not differentiated within the domain of a buddha.

Venerable Śāradvatīputra, the expression 'not differentiated' means non-discernibility. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, 'non-discernibility' means being incognizable — incognizable in conditioned phenomena, and all the way

through to the unconditioned as well, equally incognizable. Since there is absolutely nothing there that is discernible, it is therefore called non-discernible.

Venerable Śāradvatīputra, all phenomena are non-discernible. Why? Because there is no arising through which any phenomenon could abide somewhere and become discernible. Those who have entered into what is without interval have entered into the inconceivable. Those who have entered into the inconceivable have entered into the genuine. Why is that? Venerable Śāradvatīputra, because 'the genuine' means a ground that is without distinction.

Those who are endowed with the inconceivable neither go to the higher realms, nor go to the lower realms, nor go to nirvāṇa. Why is that? Because the inconceivable neither abides in approach to going and not-going, all the way through to nirvāṇa, nor in approach to going or not-going.

Venerable Śāradvatīputra, even those who dwell in the four root downfalls dwell in that which is without root. Why? Because, venerable Śāradvatīputra, in that which is without arising there is nothing called root or tip. The expression 'a monk without root' is a synonym for 'a monk without abiding.' The expression 'a conflict has arisen' is a synonym for 'one who is excessively superimposing.' Venerable Śāradvatīputra, one who conducts themselves with excessive superimposition becomes a worthy recipient of offerings in the world. Why? Because they superimpose excessively upon what is equal.

Venerable Śāradvatīputra, a monk who has faith is not a worthy recipient of what is given in faith. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, a monk who lacks faith is a worthy recipient of what is given in faith. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, a monk who is fit is not a worthy recipient of what is given in faith. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, a monk who is not fit is a worthy recipient of what is given in faith. A monk who has not demolished proper conduct is to be called an arhat in whom all defilements are exhausted."

Śāradvatīputra said: "Mañjuśrī, with what in mind do you speak thus?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Equanimity itself — that which does not properly demolish equanimity — that is proper conduct. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, with that in mind I said that a monk who has not demolished proper conduct is to be called an arhat in whom all defilements are exhausted."

"Venerable Śāradvatīputra, the expression 'one who has not crossed beyond fear' is a synonym for 'an arhat in whom all defilements are exhausted.'"

Śāradvatīputra said: "Mañjuśrī, with what in mind do you speak thus?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "If there is not even the slightest fear, then what would one cross beyond?"

Śāradvatīputra said:

Śāradvatīputra said: "Mañjuśrī, the expression 'one who has patience with the unborn' — whose word is that a synonym for?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, one who has not produced even the slightest phenomenon is to be called 'one who has patience with the unborn.'"

Śāradvatīputra said: "Mañjuśrī, the expression 'a monk who is untamed' — whose word is that a synonym for?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, the expression 'a monk who is untamed' is a synonym for 'an arhat in whom all defilements are exhausted.' Why so? Because what is untamed is tamed, and what is tamed is untamed. With that in mind, Venerable Śāradvatīputra, I said that the expression 'a monk who is untamed' is a synonym for 'an arhat in whom all defilements are exhausted.'"

Having said this, he continued: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, the expression 'one who moves in the higher mind' is a synonym for an ordinary person."

Śāradvatīputra said: "Mañjuśrī, with what in mind do you speak thus?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, because in that case one is still making it higher."

When he had spoken those words, the Venerable Śāradvatīputra said this to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, it is excellent, excellent, that you have spoken of an arhat in whom all defilements are exhausted just as it is."

Mañjuśrī replied: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, it is indeed so, just as was said. My own defilements are exhausted, yet I am not an arhat. Why so? Venerable Śāradvatīputra, because my aspiration is exhausted at the level of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. By this enumeration, Venerable Śāradvatīputra, my defilements are exhausted, yet I am not an arhat."

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, is there a category by which a bodhisattva, a great being, seated at the seat of awakening, would lack the fortune to fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, there is indeed a category by which a bodhisattva, a great being, present at the seat of awakening, would lack the fortune to fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Why so? Because in relation to awakening there is not even the slightest phenomenon, and nothing is apprehended — and for that reason it is called unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Moreover, that awakening itself is unborn. In it, there is no one who is present at the seat of awakening, no one who fully awakens to awakening, no one by whom awakening is fully awakened to, no awakening that is fully awakened to, and no one who rises from the seat of awakening — none of these can be found or apprehended. Blessed One, by this enumeration, a bodhisattva, a great being, is present at the seat of awakening and yet lacks the fortune to fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening."

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, the expression 'awakening' — whose word is that a synonym for?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, what is called 'awakening' is a synonym for the five acts of immediate consequence. Why so? Blessed One, it is because those very five acts of immediate consequence are, in the absence of any real thing, the very nature of awakening. Why so? Because awakening has the nature of the five acts of immediate consequence. Yet fully realizing the acts of immediate consequence is not awakening, and having all phenomena appear directly is also not awakening. Why so? Because all phenomena do not appear in an utterly direct manner.

None of them fully and perfectly realized those acts. From not seeing, not hearing, not seeking, through to not realizing — that is what awakening is. And yet, Blessed One, those who are possessed of manifest conceit assert those things to range from fully and perfectly awakening to making something directly manifest.

When this was said, the Blessed One spoke these words to Mañjuśrī, the youthful bodhisattva: "Mañjuśrī, do you think to yourself, 'The Tathāgata is my Tathāgata'?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, that is not so. Why? Because, Blessed One, I do not think to myself, 'The Tathāgata is my Tathāgata.' Why is that? Because, Blessed One, suchness itself is the very Tathāgata, and suchness does not cognize the Tathāgata, nor does the Tathāgata cognize suchness. Why is that? Because, Blessed One, in the ultimate sense suchness has no real existence, and the Tathāgata likewise has no real existence. Therefore, Blessed One, I do not think to myself, 'The Tathāgata is my Tathāgata.' Blessed One, what is called 'the Tathāgata' is merely a name. So with respect to what Tathāgata would one think to oneself, 'The Tathāgata is my Tathāgata'?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, do you have doubt concerning the Tathāgata?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, that is not so. Blessed One, if the Tathāgata had either arisen or fully passed beyond sorrow, and if there were something that was truly and completely established as a Tathāgata, then I would indeed have doubt concerning it."

When this was said, the Blessed One spoke these words to Mañjuśrī, the youthful bodhisattva: "Mañjuśrī, do you not think to yourself that the Tathāgata has arisen?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, if arising existed within the dharmadhātu, then I would think to myself that the Tathāgata has arisen."

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, do you not believe that buddhas, Blessed Ones, as numerous as the grains of sand in the Ganges, have fully passed beyond sorrow?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, are not the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, all of one domain within what is inconceivable?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, that is so. The buddhas, the Blessed Ones, are indeed all of one domain within what is inconceivable."

Mañjuśrī asked: "Blessed One, are they presently abiding?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, that too is so."

Mañjuśrī said: "Blessed One, for that reason, those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, as numerous as the grains of sand in the Ganges, have not fully passed beyond sorrow. Why? Because the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, are all of one domain within what is inconceivable, and that which is inconceivable is neither arising nor cessation. Therefore, Blessed One, those who, at the very time of

your own fully perfect awakening, were not yet present, and who shall become Tathāgatas, arhats, fully and perfectly awakened buddhas — they too are equally fully and perfectly awakening. Why is that?"

"It is because within what is inconceivable there is no past, no future, and no present."

The Blessed One said: "For that reason, those who think 'a Tathāgata has been born' and hold that view all the way through to 'fully passing beyond sorrow' — their abiding in the world is an error. Blessed One, these are those who cause the continuation of worldly existence to be severed."

When this had been said, the Blessed One spoke these words to young Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, for that reason, you should speak this inconceivability of the Tathāgata — this unthinkability, this incomprehensibility, this transcendence of thought — in the presence of a Tathāgata, or a non-regressing great bodhisattva, or an arhat whose defilements are exhausted. Why? Because upon hearing it, such persons will neither praise it nor reject it. Why is that? Because this is inconceivable, unthinkable, and incomprehensible."

Mañjuśrī said: "Blessed One, when all phenomena are inconceivable and unthinkable, who would praise or reject anything?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, just as the Tathāgata is incomprehensible, are not ordinary beings likewise incomprehensible?"

Mañjuśrī said: "Blessed One, ordinary beings too are likewise incomprehensible."

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, that is so. Why? Because all that can be conceived is incomprehensible."

Mañjuśrī said: "Blessed One, then why did you declare that just as the Tathāgata is incomprehensible, so too are ordinary beings incomprehensible? Is not the very nature of ordinary beings itself incomprehensible? Why so? Because, Blessed One, all phenomena are incomprehensible."

"Blessed One, those who have entered the path for the sake of nirvāṇa — they will become discouraged. Why? Because that which is incomprehensible is itself nirvāṇa. Therefore, Blessed One, there is no distinction between what is incomprehensible and nirvāṇa."

"Blessed One, those who say 'these are the phenomena of ordinary beings' and 'these are the phenomena of noble ones' — I would say to them: 'First, attend upon spiritual friends, and only then will you come to know what are the phenomena of ordinary beings and what are the phenomena of noble ones.' That is what I would say to them."

When this had been said, the Blessed One spoke these words to young Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, do you regard the Tathāgata as the highest of all sentient beings?"

Mañjuśrī said: "Blessed One, if there were some being here who were established as a sentient being, then I would regard the Tathāgata as the highest of all sentient beings. Blessed One, do you wish to assert that the Tathāgata possesses inconceivable qualities?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, do you regard the Tathāgata as endowed with inconceivable qualities?"

Mañjuśrī said: "Blessed One, if there were something here endowed with qualities that could be conceived, then I would regard the Tathāgata as endowed with inconceivable qualities."

The Blessed One then declared:

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, do you wish to assert that these śrāvakas have been tamed by the Tathāgata?"

Mañjuśrī said: "Blessed One, if there were someone who could be tamed within an inconceivable sphere, then I would wish to say that these śrāvakas have been tamed by the Tathāgata. Blessed One, the arising of a buddha is not something that abides close to benefiting or harming anyone. Why is that? Because this sphere simply abides as it is, and this sphere is unmixed — for it is an inconceivable sphere. Within that sphere, from śrāvakas on one end to ordinary beings on the other, nothing is to be apprehended."

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, do you not wish to assert that the Tathāgata is an unsurpassed field of merit?"

Mañjuśrī said: "Blessed One, it is because there are no things that the Tathāgata is a field of merit, and for that very reason it is an unsurpassed field of merit. It is not a full field, nor an empty field, nor something that is not a field — and for that very reason it is an unsurpassed field of merit. Blessed One, moreover, in that field no dharma whatsoever comes to be truly established, nor does it come to be extinguished — and thus it is a field of

merit. A seed planted in it neither multiplies nor fully declines."

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, from what standpoint do you say that a seed planted in that field neither multiplies nor fully declines?"

Mañjuśrī said: "Blessed One, that field is inconceivable, and therefore it is a field of merit."

At that moment, by the power of the buddha, the great earth shook in six ways. Sixteen thousand monks (bhikṣus) were liberated in mind from the defilements without clinging. Seven hundred nuns, three hundred laymen, forty thousand laywomen, and sixty trillion gods dwelling in the desire realm all attained the dust-free, stainless eye of the Dharma with respect to all phenomena.

Then the venerable Ānanda rose from his seat, arranged his robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, joined his palms toward the Blessed One, bowed in the direction where the Blessed One was, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what was the cause, what was the condition, for this great trembling of the earth that occurred in the world?"

When this was said, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Ānanda as follows: "Ānanda, this Dharma discourse called 'Revealing the Field of Merit' — the past blessed buddhas also proclaimed it in this very place. Ānanda, that is the cause and that is the condition for this trembling of the earth in the world."

Then the venerable Śāriputra addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, Mañjuśrī is an inconceivable glory. Why is that? Because whatever eloquence he possesses, that very eloquence is itself inconceivable."

Then the Blessed One declared to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, what the monk Śāriputra has said is just so. Youthful Mañjuśrī, whatever eloquence you possess — all of it is inconceivable."

When this was declared, the youthful Mañjuśrī addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is inconceivable cannot be spoken of with eloquence."

"If the inconceivable were to become eloquence, it would no longer be inconceivability itself. And whatever is the inconceivable that is not inconceivable — that is nothing at all. Blessed One, all sounds are inconceivable, and inconceivability itself is not sound. What is not sound, and what is neither sound nor the absence of sound, cannot be taught."

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, do you enter into the meditative absorption of the inconceivable?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, I do not. I do not enter into the meditative absorption of the inconceivable. Why is that? Because, Blessed One, I myself am the meditative absorption of the inconceivable. Blessed One, if I were conceivable, I would enter into the meditative absorption of the inconceivable. Blessed One, since what is called meditative absorption is itself unthinkable, inconceivable, and beyond reckoning, how could I enter into the meditative absorption of the inconceivable? And yet, Blessed One, long ago, at the time of my very beginning, I thought to myself: 'I will enter into the meditative absorption of the inconceivable.' But now, having entered into that absorption and abiding in it, I no longer think: 'I will continue to abide in this absorption.' Why is that? Because at whatever moment I am abiding in this absorption, at that very moment this absorption is beyond designation."

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, when the youthful Mañjuśrī abides in this meditative absorption of the inconceivable, does the mind not come to rest? Blessed One, can there be any other absorption more peaceful than this meditative absorption of the inconceivable?"

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī spoke to the venerable Śāradvatīputra: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, you ask whether there is some other absorption more peaceful than this meditative absorption of the inconceivable. But venerable Śāradvatīputra, how do you know this meditative absorption of the inconceivable to be peaceful? Venerable Śāradvatīputra, if this meditative absorption of the inconceivable existed and could be focused upon as an object, then there might indeed be another absorption more peaceful than it."

Śāradvatīputra said: "Mañjuśrī, is this meditative absorption of the inconceivable then non-existent and without any object?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, it is just so. That is the meditative absorption of the inconceivable — and therefore this meditative absorption of the inconceivable is non-existent and without any object."

"And yet, Venerable Śāradvatīputra, there is no one who has not attained the meditative absorption of the inconceivable. Venerable Śāradvatīputra, every single sentient being has attained the meditative absorption of the inconceivable. Why is that? Every thought is inconceivable, and whatever is

inconceivable is the meditative absorption of the inconceivable. Therefore all sentient beings have attained this meditative absorption of the inconceivable."

This is the second and final section.

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to Mañjuśrī, the youthful bodhisattva: "Excellent, excellent, Mañjuśrī! You have taught all these profound matters of the deep just as they are. Indeed, Mañjuśrī, you have served the Victors of the past — you have long practiced the pure conduct of non-referential meditation. But Mañjuśrī, do you think: 'I am abiding in the Perfection of Wisdom, and therefore I speak thus'?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, if I were to abide in the Perfection of Wisdom and yet speak thus, then I would be abiding in reference to an object and would be speaking thus. Abiding in the perception of self all the way through to abiding in the perception of things — I would be speaking thus. Therefore, abiding in the Perfection of Wisdom, I do not speak thus. Why? Blessed One, if the Perfection of Wisdom were to become a place of abiding, or if it were to become something that is not a place of abiding, then it would cease to be the Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, my place of abiding is the place of abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom — a place that has no abiding, no arising from anywhere, no occasion, no production. In that way, that place of abiding is not the place of abiding of any phenomenon whatsoever. Therefore that place of abiding is an inconceivable place of abiding — it is the place of abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom.

"Blessed One, what is called the Perfection of Wisdom is the non-arising of all phenomena — that is the Perfection of Wisdom. What is called the Perfection of Wisdom is this: it is the supreme word for the inconceivable basic space. Whatever is the inconceivable basic space, that is the basic space of non-arising. Whatever is the basic space of non-arising, that is the dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena. Whatever is the dharmadhātu, that is the basic space of total non-production. Whatever is the basic space of total non-production, that is the inconceivable basic space. Whatever is the inconceivable basic space, that is the basic space of self. Whatever is the basic space of self, that is the basic space of the Perfection of Wisdom. In that way, the basic space of the Perfection of Wisdom and the basic space of self are not two and are not to be distinguished as two. Because these two are not two and are not to be distinguished as two, this is the inconceivable basic space. Because this is the inconceivable basic space, this is the basic space of

non-arising. Because this is the basic space of non-arising, this is the dharmadhātu. Because this is the dharmadhātu, this is the basic space of total non-production. Because this is the basic space of total non-production, this is the inconceivable basic space. Because this is the inconceivable basic space, this is the basic space of self. Because this is the basic space of self, this is the basic space of the Perfection of Wisdom. And because this is the basic space of the Perfection of Wisdom, this is the inconceivable basic space."

Because this is the inconceivable basic space, this is the basic space free from true establishment. Whatever is free from true establishment does not exist. Whatever does not exist cannot be destroyed. Whatever cannot be destroyed is inconceivable. Thus the basic space of the Tathāgata and this basic space of self are not two and are not to be separated into two.

As for the Blessed One's declaration that "meditating on self is meditating on the Perfection of Wisdom" — why is this so? It is because, Blessed One, what is called the Perfection of Wisdom is a synonym for the basic space of self. And why is that? Because, Blessed One, whoever seeks the basic space of self seeks the basic space free from attachment. And whoever seeks that which is itself free from attachment seeks no phenomenon whatsoever. Why is this so? It is because inconceivable primordial wisdom is the wisdom of the buddhas, and knowing nothing with respect to any phenomenon whatsoever is the wisdom of the buddhas. Why is this so? Because in the ultimate sense that wisdom does not exist — and how could that which does not exist in the ultimate sense turn the wheel of Dharma?

When that wisdom does not exist in the ultimate sense, that wisdom is free from attachment. When that wisdom is free from attachment, that wisdom is free from substantiality. When that wisdom is free from substantiality, that wisdom is without an object. When that wisdom is without an object, that wisdom is non-abiding. When that wisdom is non-abiding, that wisdom is without a support. When that wisdom is without a support, that wisdom is unproduced, unattained, and will not arise. Why is this so? Because that wisdom is not compounded by qualities, nor is it compounded by what is not a quality, and therefore it is uncompounded. Why is this so? Because that wisdom is inconceivable, and for that reason how could it be described as either a quality or not a quality? Since that wisdom is inconceivable, that wisdom is unthinkable. One who knows it thus — that is the wisdom of the buddhas in the mode of non-apprehension. By that wisdom no phenomenon whatsoever was fully and perfectly awakened to or known. That wisdom has

not come from the earlier limit or from the later limit. That wisdom was not previously arisen, nor was it previously non-arisen — and because it was previously non-arisen, whatever has not arisen will not set and will not be cut off. There is no other wisdom comparable to that wisdom; therefore that wisdom is inconceivable and without compare. In that wisdom, a beginning, middle, or end are not apprehended; therefore that wisdom is like space. In that wisdom, equality and inequality are not apprehended; therefore that wisdom is the equal of the unequal. In that wisdom, no other wisdom comparable to it is apprehended; therefore that wisdom is without equal.

Then the Blessed One spoke thus to Mañjuśrī, the ever-youthful: "Mañjuśrī, is this wisdom not immutable?" Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, this wisdom is unmade; therefore it is immutable. Blessed One, consider this analogy: an unstamped kārṣāpaṇa coin is counted as neither exchanged nor unexchanged."

"Blessed One, likewise this wisdom is unmade, unaccomplished, unborn, undrawn forth, and unceased; therefore it is immutable."

Then the Blessed One spoke thus to Mañjuśrī, the ever-youthful: "Mañjuśrī, who among those here is inclined toward this teaching of Tathāgata wisdom?" Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, those who are neither of the nature of saṃsāra nor of the nature of complete nirvāṇa, those who are not moved by the view of the transitory collection, and those who have not imbibed attachment, aversion, or delusion — those are the ones who are so inclined. And why is that? One who has not imbibed cannot become one who has imbibed, nor can they come to be one who has fully imbibed. Those who have neither passed beyond saṃsāra nor count as being within saṃsāra, and those who are not separated from the path yet do not generate the perception of a path — it is those people who will seek the meaning of this teaching."

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One declared to Mañjuśrī, the ever-youthful: "Excellent, Mañjuśrī! Excellent! These words of yours are well spoken."

Then at that time the venerable Mahākāśyapa addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, when you are no longer present, will there be those who will listen to, be inclined toward, seek out, and firmly take hold of this profound Dharma-discipline and this profound Perfection of Wisdom?"

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One declared to the venerable Mahākāśyapa: "Kāśyapa, even within this very assembly there are monks,

nuns, laymen, and laywomen who, in the future, will listen to, be inclined toward, fully learn, and firmly take hold of this profound Dharma-discipline and this profound Perfection of Wisdom. Kāśyapa, consider this analogy: if a householder or a householder's son were to lose a precious jewel worth many hundreds of thousands, he would become pained and mentally distressed. But when that very jewel is found, joy and mental ease would arise and all tormenting mental preoccupation would be absent. Kāśyapa, likewise those monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen, so long as they have not heard this profound Perfection of Wisdom — unborn, unoriginated, and naturally completely passed into nirvāṇa, through to the absence of things — they will think to themselves: 'We have not heard this profound Perfection of Wisdom, unborn, unoriginated, and naturally completely passed into nirvāṇa through to the absence of things.' When at another time they come to hear it, they will become joyful, at ease, and glad, and all tormenting mental preoccupation will be absent. They will say these words: 'By hearing today this profound Perfection of Wisdom — unborn, without things, and unoriginated — we have seen a buddha and have likewise paid homage to the Tathāgata.' Kāśyapa, consider this further analogy: the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three (Skt. Trāyastriṃśa), upon seeing the pārijāta tree with its buds just beginning to open, think: 'Before long, in no great time, all the blossoms will burst forth,' and they become glad and greatly delighted. Kāśyapa, likewise those monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen, upon hearing this profound Perfection of Wisdom — unborn, unoriginated, through to the absence of things — will become glad and greatly delighted. Those who in the future will hear of this profound Perfection of Wisdom as unborn,"

unoriginated, through to the absence of things — those who will become glad and greatly delighted upon hearing it, know, Kāśyapa, that they too abide right here within this very retinue of mine. And those who in a future time will become glad and greatly delighted — know that through that gladness and great delight, before long, without much delay, all the blossoms of all the qualities of a buddha will burst into full flower.

Kāśyapa, likewise, those who in a future time, after the Tathāgatas of the past have gone beyond, will abide and engage with this profound Perfection of Wisdom — unborn, unoriginated, through to the absence of things — know, Kāśyapa, that this too is the blessing of the buddhas, the power of the buddhas.

Therefore, Kāśyapa, those who hear this profound Perfection of Wisdom — unborn, unoriginated, through to the absence of things — and feel joy, know, Kāśyapa, that this is not the first time they have heard it. Kāśyapa, consider this analogy: when a jeweler, upon seeing a precious jewel, feels joy at that very moment, one should understand that this jeweler is not seeing the precious jewel for the first time — he has continually been seeing precious jewels from long before.

Kāśyapa, likewise, those who upon hearing this profound Perfection of Wisdom — unborn, unoriginated, through to the absence of things — feel glad and greatly delighted, become pleased, elated, and mentally at ease, know, Kāśyapa, that this is not the first time they have heard it. Kāśyapa, those people will speak as follows: "Speak to us again precisely this teaching that Mañjuśrī in his youthful form has set forth, from unborn to the absence of things and unoriginated." Those people will have previously attended upon Mañjuśrī in his youthful form.

Kāśyapa, consider this further analogy: suppose a person traveled to some village, town, settlement, or whatever locality, on account of some matter. Then at another time, someone went to that person and praised that city, describing the beautiful parks, the beautiful districts, the beautiful ponds, the beautiful pleasure groves, the beautiful springs, the beautiful pools, the beautiful lakes, the beautiful flowers, and the beautiful fruits. Upon hearing this, that person felt joy and mental ease arose within, and again and again sought out that very person, saying: "Please, speak it again!" One should understand that this person had previously already experienced that city with its beautiful parks, its beautiful districts, its beautiful ponds, its beautiful pleasure groves, its beautiful springs, its beautiful pools, its beautiful lakes, its beautiful flowers, and its beautiful fruits. Why is this? Because upon hearing it, that person felt extraordinary gladness and great delight, and delight arose, and he became pleased, elated, and mentally at ease.

Kāśyapa, likewise, those who have attended upon Mañjuśrī in his youthful form and have gone to him again and again to ask questions — when they hear this profound Perfection of Wisdom, unborn, unoriginated, through to the absence of things, they become greatly delighted and pleased, generating great joy and gladness, and they will speak these words: "How wondrous indeed is this very Perfection of Wisdom, which has been taught from unborn and unoriginated through to the absence of things, just as it has been heard."

When this had been declared,

The venerable Mahākāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what are the aspects, signs, and marks of those sons and daughters of good family who will arise in the future — those marks the Blessed One has declared?"

The Blessed One replied: "Kāśyapa, just as you have said, it is so. The aspects, signs, and marks that I have now set forth — these very ones are the aspects, signs, and marks of those sons and daughters of good family who will arise in the future."

Then Mañjuśrī in his youthful form addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, that Dharma is without aspect and without sign. And the Perfection of Wisdom too, from being without aspect through to being without mark — if this is so, then what kind of aspect, sign, or mark could there be? The teaching of the Dharma that the Blessed One has given is likewise without aspect, without sign, and without mark. Since that is so, how will the Blessed One teach what is without aspect, without sign, and without mark?"

When this was asked, the Blessed One declared to Mañjuśrī in his youthful form: "Mañjuśrī, when this profound Perfection of Wisdom — from being supremely unborn through to the absence of things — is taught, those who from the beginning of conviction through to full penetration carry it through to completion: they themselves are the aspects, signs, and marks of those sons and daughters of good family. Mañjuśrī, wherever the Perfection of Wisdom is taught, all the qualities of a buddha are to be seen there. There, the inconceivable is to be seen as being taught.

"Mañjuśrī, in former times, when I was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, I accomplished wholesome roots — the very wholesome roots by which one fully and perfectly awakens to unsurpassed, complete, and perfect awakening. Any son or daughter of good family who wishes to accomplish those same wholesome roots should listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, have conviction in it, write it down, hold it, read it, receive its oral transmission, recite it, commit it to verse, penetrate it thoroughly, attend to it properly, and meditate on it — and moreover should make offerings of flowers, incense, fragrant substances, garlands, ointments, powders, garments, parasols, victory banners, pennants, victory pennants, lamps, and so forth, to whatever extent is possible and affordable. They should pay homage and show reverence.

"Any son or daughter of good family who wishes to pass beyond all that which śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas accomplish should also listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, through to paying homage and showing reverence.

"Mañjuśrī, any son or daughter of good family who wishes to enter the stage of non-regression in such a way as to enter it irreversibly should also listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, through to paying homage and showing reverence.

"Mañjuśrī, any son or daughter of good family who wishes to have conviction that all phenomena whatsoever are equal in being unborn should also listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, through to paying homage and showing reverence.

"Mañjuśrī, any son or daughter of good family who wishes to fully and perfectly awaken to all the qualities of a buddha should also listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, through to paying homage and showing reverence."

"Mañjuśrī, any son or daughter of good family who wishes to have conviction in this most profound teaching that all phenomena have been fully and perfectly awakened to by the Tathāgatas should also listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, through to paying homage and showing reverence. And why? Because there is no one who fully and perfectly awakens, no one by whom full and perfect awakening is achieved, and no phenomenon to be fully and perfectly awakened to — for none of these can be apprehended.

"Any son or daughter of good family who wishes to understand and have conviction in this very meaning should also listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, through to paying homage and showing reverence.

"Any son or daughter of good family who wishes to have such conviction as this: that there is no phenomenon whatsoever that is not awakening — should also listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, through to paying homage and showing reverence.

"Any son or daughter of good family who wishes to be free of conceptual thought regarding all phenomena should also listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, through to paying homage and showing reverence. And why? Because the Perfection of Wisdom neither destroys, nor produces, nor demonstrates the thorough establishment of any phenomenon whatsoever.

"Any son or daughter of good family who wishes to enter into the understanding that all phenomena are neither defiled nor purified should also listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, through to paying homage and

showing reverence.

"Any son or daughter of good family who wishes to have conviction in and enter into the understanding that all phenomena are neither past, nor future, nor presently arisen should also listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, through to paying homage and showing reverence. And why? Because, Mañjuśrī, what is unborn is neither past, nor future, nor presently arisen. And why? Because, Mañjuśrī, all phenomena rest upon the unborn.

"Any son or daughter of good family who wishes to understand all such phenomena without doubt should also listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, through to paying homage and showing reverence.

"Mañjuśrī, any son or daughter of good family who wishes to hear, understand, have conviction in, and enter into what it means for the wheel of Dharma to be turned in twelve aspects, spoken three times — should also listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, through to paying homage and showing reverence.

"Any son or daughter of good family who wishes to pervade all sentient beings with loving-kindness while also wishing not to abide in the perception of them as sentient beings, and who wishes to engage with the entire world while also wishing to understand that the entire world cannot be apprehended — should also listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, through to paying homage and showing reverence.

"Any son or daughter of good family who wishes to understand all phenomena as far as their being unborn should train in this very Perfection of Wisdom in a manner that apprehends nothing whatsoever."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is the quality without qualities — the benefit and the merit — of the Perfection of Wisdom?"

"Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom has no capacity, does not abandon anything, does not destroy anything, and does not take up any phenomenon whatsoever.

It is without wavering, without abandonment, and without activity. The Perfection of Wisdom does not know essential nature, does not see essential nature, does not bestow any phenomenon whatsoever, is not in conflict with any phenomenon, and does not differentiate any phenomenon as separate. Blessed One, what then is the quality of the Perfection of Wisdom? What is its benefit? Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom does not make all phenomena

into one, does not make all phenomena separate, has not acted, has nothing to do, does not destroy what is inferior, does not bestow the phenomena of ordinary beings, the phenomena of arhats, the phenomena of bodhisattvas, or the phenomena of buddhas, does not diminish them, does not take up saṃsāra and does not abandon nirvāṇa, does not bestow the phenomena of buddhas, does not destroy them, does not conceptualize them, is not without conceptualization, does not act, does not destroy, does not generate all phenomena, does not cease them, does not make them annihilated, does not make them permanent, does not make them come, does not make them go, does not make them isolated, does not make them non-isolated, does not make them dual, and does not make them non-dual. What quality is this? What benefit is this?"

When this was said, the Blessed One spoke these words to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, from the absence of things through to the absence of activity — all of this should be understood as the quality of this Perfection of Wisdom.

"Mañjuśrī, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to train in the bodhisattva's meditative absorption, who wishes to accomplish the bodhisattva's meditative absorption, who wishes to behold, while abiding in that absorption, all buddhas, the Blessed Ones, as well as their buddha-fields, who wishes to know their names, who wishes to make unsurpassed offerings to them, who wishes to enter into the Dharma they teach, and who wishes to have confidence — such a one should train in this very Perfection of Wisdom in the manner of one who trains without training."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, why is this called the Perfection of Wisdom?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, it is called the Perfection of Wisdom because it is unborn and unceasing. Moreover, because it is primordially at peace, without arising, without activity — from the absence of activity through to the absence of things — whatever is without things, that is the Perfection of Wisdom.

"Mañjuśrī, therefore, bodhisattvas, great beings, should understand how to meditate on the Perfection of Wisdom. That which is not the domain of any phenomenon is precisely the domain of bodhisattvas, great beings. One who practices in this manner is said to be a bodhisattva, a great being, who has entered the domain. In this way, that which is not a domain is itself the domain

of all vehicles. Why is this? This domain is unmade; therefore it is called 'not a domain.'"

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, by practicing what does a bodhisattva, a great being, swiftly come to fully realize unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening?"

When this was said, the Blessed One spoke these words to the youthful Mañjuśrī:

"Mañjuśrī, by practicing the Perfection of Wisdom, a bodhisattva, a great being, will swiftly come to fully realize unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. Mañjuśrī, there is a meditative absorption called the Single Array. By practicing that meditative absorption, a bodhisattva, a great being, will swiftly come to fully realize unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening."

When this was said, the youthful Mañjuśrī addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, enter the meditative absorption of the Single Array? And why is it called the meditative absorption of the Single Array?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, this expression 'Single Array' is a synonym for non-arising. One who is a son or daughter of good family wishing to enter the meditative absorption of the Single Array must first fully inquire into the Perfection of Wisdom, and after that they will enter the meditative absorption of the Single Array. Why is this? Mañjuśrī, non-arising is undisturbed — it cannot be disturbed, it is not something to be stirred up, it is inconceivable, not to be thought about, beyond the reach of thought.

"Mañjuśrī, a son or daughter of good family wishing to enter the meditative absorption of the Single Array should rely on teachers who point out the path of seclusion, should delight in non-busyness, and then, having put aside all signs from mind, should sit in the cross-legged posture and, in a manner of non-fixation, hold a single Tathāgata in mind. One should also hold all phenomena in mind. One should take up the name of whichever Tathāgata one holds in mind. Having heard and fixed upon that name, one should sit facing the direction where that Tathāgata resides, gazing directly toward it, and hold it in mind. If one holds that very Tathāgata in mind in this way, then through that act of holding in mind, one will come to hold in mind all buddha Blessed Ones — those of the past, those of the future, and those of the

present. Why is this? Because the nature of the Tathāgata is singular.

"Mañjuśrī, just as the qualities of buddhahood of a single Tathāgata are immeasurable and the eloquence immeasurable, so too, Mañjuśrī, it should be understood that upon attaining the meditative absorption of the Single Array, one comes to know immeasurable distinctions in the enumeration of phenomena pertaining to the single principle of non-arising. All those who attain this here, and all those teachings spoken by the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and fully awakened buddhas, and all those teachings retained by Ānanda — all those enumerations of the Dharma will become manifest here. Having accomplished this meditative absorption of the Single Array, one will abide for as long as one's lifespan extends and will teach the Dharma with its context.

"Mañjuśrī, concerning this, if certain practitioners of the bodhisattva vehicle should think, 'What is this meditative absorption of the Single Array?' — to them one should say: 'Take up and hold correctly this accomplishment of inconceivable qualities, and to whatever degree you take it up correctly and abide in it, to that same degree you will come to see the qualities of this meditative absorption — so, in accordance with what has been taught, be without timidity.'

"This meditative absorption is for those who hold a fixating view, and —"

cannot be established by those who hold a view of things as substantially real, all the way up to those who hold a view of things as existent.

Mañjuśrī, consider this simile. A man possesses a priceless jewel that has never been polished. Another man comes to him and says: "Good sir, what is the worth of this jewel? What qualities does it possess?" And the man replies: "Good sir, know that the qualities of this jewel are immeasurable — immeasurability itself is what you must understand." Then that other man, wishing to polish the jewel, leaves it with the first man and says: "Good sir, first polish this jewel, and then you will come to know it." So the second man takes the jewel from the first, polishes it with the implements of polishing, and through polishing it in that way, the jewel becomes priceless. Just as, in whatever degree he polishes the jewel, to that same degree the qualities of the jewel come to be seen — so too, Mañjuśrī, when a son of good family or a daughter of good family enters into meditative absorption and engages with this meditative absorption, at that very moment and to that same degree the qualities of this meditative absorption come to be seen.

Mañjuśrī, consider this further simile. The rays of the solar orb leave no quarter of that orb's circumference uncovered. Likewise, Mañjuśrī, one who has attained and entered into the meditative absorption of the Single Array will, through that attainment, teach nothing whatsoever that is not a teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom. And whoever understands it in this way will see no phenomenon whatsoever that contradicts non-arising.

Mañjuśrī, consider this further simile. If four men draw water from the four directions of the great ocean, each and every one of them draws and takes up water that is of one single taste — the taste of salt. Likewise, Mañjuśrī, all the various teachings that have been taught are of one single taste — the taste of non-arising, the taste of the absence of substantial things, the taste of freedom from attachment, the taste of thorough liberation, and the taste of cessation.

Mañjuśrī, therefore, whatever teachings a son of good family or a daughter of good family who is endowed with this meditative absorption may teach, all of those teachings will be of one single taste — the taste of non-arising, the taste of the absence of substantial things, the taste of freedom from attachment, the taste of thorough liberation, and the taste of cessation.

Having attained this meditative absorption, if a son of good family or a daughter of good family so desires, I will explain, elaborate upon, and set forth in detail whatever has been taught. Mañjuśrī, thus, whatever a son of good family or a daughter of good family who has attained this meditative absorption may teach, all of it will be taught in the manner of non-apprehension — as unborn, as unarisen, and as devoid of substantial existence.

Mañjuśrī, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, who has attained this meditative absorption will swiftly perfect the qualities that conduce to awakening and will swiftly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Mañjuśrī, furthermore, when the bodhisattva, the great being, sees neither arising nor ceasing, neither identity nor difference, anywhere from the domain of self all the way to the dharmadhātu, then, Mañjuśrī, such a bodhisattva, the great being, possessed of that kind of patient acceptance, will swiftly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

A son of good family who does not long for unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, and —

this patient acceptance of non-conceptuality will become the means of attaining the qualities of a bodhisattva and the qualities of a buddha. And as for one who does not aspire to awakening for the sake of becoming a buddha himself — I declare that such a son of good family, endowed with this patient acceptance, will swiftly attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

One who, believing that all phenomena are qualities of a buddha, does not become despondent — I declare that such a person is irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, and is to be called one who is never separated from all the qualities of a buddha.

Any son or daughter of good family who, upon hearing this teaching, does not become confused and does not fall into doubt — such a person too is to be called one who is never separated from all the qualities of a buddha.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the youthful Mañjuśrī addressed the Blessed One thus: Blessed One, does unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening arise from causes?

The Blessed One replied: Mañjuśrī, it does not. Unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening is not a cause, nor does it arise from causes. Why is that? Because non-arising and the absence of inherent existence are neither a cause nor something that arises from a cause. And why is that? Because all phenomena are unborn.

Therefore, Mañjuśrī, I declare that any son or daughter of good family who, upon hearing this teaching, does not become despondent is irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Therefore, Mañjuśrī, any monk, nun, layman, or laywoman who does not become despondent toward this profound Perfection of Wisdom, and who does not become disheartened — such persons have gone for refuge to me. They have gone forth under me. I am their Teacher.

Mañjuśrī, any son or daughter of good family who does not train in this profound Perfection of Wisdom is not training in the training of a bodhisattva.

Mañjuśrī, consider this example: all assemblages of the four elements, assemblages of seeds, grasses, creeping plants, medicines, and forests, whatever there may be of them — all of these grow in dependence upon the great earth. Just so, Mañjuśrī, whatever wholesome qualities there may be belonging to bodhisattvas, great beings — all of them, when embraced by the Perfection of Wisdom, grow, expand, and become vast, and they do not fall

away from unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the youthful Mañjuśrī addressed the Blessed One thus: Blessed One, will there be those in this Jambudvīpa — in villages, cities, towns, or regions — who will hold and teach this Perfection of Wisdom as the Blessed One has taught and expounded it?

When this was asked, the Blessed One spoke thus to the youthful Mañjuśrī: Mañjuśrī, those who hear this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom in the present life and make the aspiration, "Even after exchanging this life, may I hear this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom" — such persons will, after hearing it, come to cultivate it in the manner of meditating without extensive elaboration.

Mañjuśrī, those who hear this profound Perfection of Wisdom, and having heard it, rejoice —

— those who attain such expansive joy, I do not consider to have little virtue at their root.

Mañjuśrī, if someone should wish to hear this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom, one might say to that person: "Good son, what will you accomplish by listening to it? Upon hearing it, you will be left without faith, turning away in frustration." Why so? Because in this teaching no phenomenon whatsoever has been shown to be fully established; neither the arising nor the cessation of the phenomena of ordinary beings has been taught; and neither the arising, cessation, nor attainment of the phenomena of those in training, of those beyond training, of pratyekabuddhas, nor of buddhas has been taught. One should say this to such a person.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the youthful Mañjuśrī addressed him with these words: Blessed One, if any monk, nun, layman, or laywoman were to come to me and ask, "What is the teaching on the Dharma that the Tathāgata gave today?" — Blessed One, to such a questioner I would reply in these words: "It is a teaching that is not at variance with anything at all." Why so? Blessed One, because there is no such thing whatsoever as a teaching on arising without arising and cessation without cessation — that teaching is not easy for any sentient being to seek. Why so? Because there is no sentient being at all who can be apprehended as an object.

Blessed One, moreover, I would say to such a person: "What has been taught is the phenomenon called non-arising." Why so? Blessed One, because all

phenomena are equal in being without arising.

In that teaching, just as the phenomena of arhats do not dismantle the phenomena of ordinary beings, so too it has not been taught that arhats transcend something superior.

Blessed One, furthermore, I would say to such a person: "In this teaching of the Dharma, there is no sentient being who has attained nirvāṇa, who is attaining nirvāṇa, or who will attain nirvāṇa." Why so? Blessed One, because sentient beings are utterly without apprehensible existence. Blessed One, if I were asked in this way, I would respond thus.

Blessed One, if someone wishes to hear this profound Perfection of Wisdom from me and asks, "What did you discuss today with the Blessed One?" — to that person I would say: "If you wish to hear it, then do not settle your mind on the thought 'I am listening.' Do not give rise to the thought 'I am listening.' Good sir, cultivate the kind of wisdom that is like the wisdom of an illusory person — and by means of such wisdom, one will be able to know this teaching of the Dharma. Good sir, if you wish to hear this teaching of the Dharma, then abide as a bird's track in the sky — and in that way, you will be able to hear this teaching of the Dharma. Good sir, if you wish to hear this teaching of the Dharma, do not apprehend duality, and do not apprehend non-duality either. Why so? Because in this teaching there is nothing that can be fully expressed as twofold, nor anything that can be expressed as non-dual. If you wish to hear this teaching of the Dharma, do not demolish perceptions of self, do not pass beyond established views, do not apprehend the phenomena of buddhas as something higher, and do not shift away from the phenomena of ordinary beings." This is what I would say.

Blessed One, to whoever wishes to hear from me and asks, I would speak and instruct in just this way.

Thus this is how I would present it. If a son or daughter of good family who is asking abides and stands in this way, remaining in this mudrā of fearlessness, I shall continue to teach them this Perfection of Wisdom until it is born, until things come to be, and until they have arisen.

When this was said, the Blessed One spoke thus to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Excellent! Excellent, Mañjuśrī! You have spoken these words well. To a son or daughter of good family you should also say this afterwards: 'If you wish to behold the Tathāgata, cultivate this very Perfection of Wisdom in the manner of non-cultivation. A son or daughter of good family who wishes to pay

homage and reverence to the Tathāgata should train in this very Perfection of Wisdom in the manner of non-referencing. A son or daughter of good family who wishes to say "The Tathāgata is my Teacher" should likewise train in this very Perfection of Wisdom in the manner of non-referencing. A son or daughter of good family who wishes to fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening should train in this very Perfection of Wisdom in the manner of non-fabrication. A son or daughter of good family who wishes to attain mastery in all meditative absorptions should train in this very Perfection of Wisdom in the manner of non-referencing. A son or daughter of good family who wishes to enter into all meditative absorptions should likewise train in this very Perfection of Wisdom in the manner of non-referencing.' Why so? Because those meditative absorptions are not made or constructed.

A son or daughter of good family who wishes to attain even the omniscient wisdom endowed with the supreme of all aspects should train in this very Perfection of Wisdom in the manner of non-substantiality. Why so? Because the omniscient wisdom endowed with the supreme of all aspects is, in just this way, not made, not arisen, and without inherent substantiality.

A son or daughter of good family who wishes to know that all phenomena have definite arising, and that there is no phenomenon whatsoever that does not have definite arising, should train in this very Perfection of Wisdom up to and including the manner of non-substantiality. All phenomena have definite non-arising, and there is no phenomenon whatsoever that has definite arising. Why so? Because all phenomena are unborn. These phenomena do not exist as they are expressed; what is inexpressible neither exists nor is it something that can be referenced. A son or daughter of good family who wishes to know it in just this way should train in this very Perfection of Wisdom up to and including the manner of non-substantiality.

All sentient beings act for the sake of awakening, and there is no sentient being whatsoever that does not act for the sake of awakening. If one wishes to be free of despondency with regard to this, a son or daughter of good family should train in this very Perfection of Wisdom up to and including the manner of non-substantiality. Why so? Because all phenomena are equal to awakening. Just as all phenomena are equal to awakening, and—"

Just as awakening is, so too are all sentient beings. Just as all sentient beings conduct themselves, so too is that. Because there is no inherent existence, all conduct is conduct without conduct. And that too is awakening — and what

awakening is, that is also birthlessness; that too is non-arising. A son or daughter of good family who wishes to be free of despondency with respect to such a Dharma as this should train in this very Perfection of Wisdom up to and including the manner of non-substantiality and birthlessness.

Mañjuśrī, everything from the magical displays of the Tathāgata through to the sport of the Tathāgata — all of that too is taught from this very Perfection of Wisdom. Why so? Because there is nothing to be taught: the Perfection of Wisdom does not show anything.

Mañjuśrī, if I were to declare that monks, nuns, laymen, or laywomen who take up even a single four-line verse from this Perfection of Wisdom, who make it thoroughly complete, who bear it, recite it, and teach it rightly, are irreversible — what need is there to speak of those who establish it as suchness? Those sons and daughters of good family should be recognized as certain of awakening.

Those who, upon hearing this profound Perfection of Wisdom — its birthlessness, non-substantiality, and non-arising — do not become frightened, terrified, or dismayed: they dwell in the domain of the buddhas. And if they go on with faith from there, they will become certain of all the qualities of the buddhas.

Mañjuśrī, this seal, which has been authorized by me, known by the Tathāgata, and properly confirmed by all arhats, should be placed here. This seal is placed for those who have realized equality. This thoroughly reveals non-attachment up to and including all the qualities of the buddhas.

Mañjuśrī, a son or daughter of good family of the bodhisattva vehicle who has been sealed with this seal is not one destined to fall into the lower realms. Nor is he or she one destined to fall to the level of the śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas, or to enter upon it.

Then at that time Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods) and the sons of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three scattered divine sandalwood powder, divine golden powder, divine mandāra flowers and great mandāra flowers, divine incense, divine blue lotuses, kumuda flowers, white lotuses, and the sounds of divine music as offerings to this Perfection of Wisdom, and also scattered them upon the Blessed One and upon the youthful Mañjuśrī. Having scattered these, they spoke thus: "By this root of virtue, may those who have been sealed with this seal make offerings to this most precious and unsurpassed Dharma, and may they hear it again and again in future

lifetimes."

Śakra also spoke these words: "Blessed One, I will strive so that this profound Perfection of Wisdom — through all its qualities of non-arising and birthlessness — may come to be practiced in this Jambudvīpa, may come to resound in the ears of such sons and daughters of good family, and may enable those very beings to thoroughly accomplish all the qualities of the buddhas."

"Blessed One, may this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom reach the ears of sons and daughters of good family with only a little effort; and may those sons and daughters of good family who, upon hearing it, develop faith, and who having developed faith take it up, make it thoroughly complete, and bear it — may they know, without any doubt, that this has been accomplished for them by the gods."

When these words had been spoken —

The Blessed One then spoke these words to Śakra, lord of the gods: "Kauśika, it is so. Regard those sons and daughters of good family as ones for whom all the qualities of the buddhas will be accomplished. Know with certainty that they are destined for unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening."

Then Mañjuśrī, the Ever-Youthful, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, may this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom be a blessing for those sons and daughters of good family. Sugata, may it be a blessing." The moment these words were spoken, in that very instant, by the power of the buddhas, the great earth trembled in six ways. And the moment the great earth trembled, the Blessed One smiled. The moment the Blessed One smiled, in that very instant, as the Tathāgata bestowed his blessing upon this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom, this entire great trichiliocosm world-system was pervaded by a great radiance.

Then Mañjuśrī, the Ever-Youthful, addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, this is a foretoken of the Tathāgata's blessing upon this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom." The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī, it is so. Mañjuśrī, these are indeed the foretokens of the blessing of this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom. By these signs, one should know that this teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom has been blessed.

"Mañjuśrī, those who neither abandon nor reject any phenomenon whatsoever, and who do not praise it either — know that those people have been sealed

with this seal. Why is that? Because when there is an object, one comes to abandon and to praise. Mañjuśrī, therefore it is for the sake of those who are sealed with this seal that I have placed this seal — for having heard this, they neither point out nor distinguish any phenomenon whatsoever. Why is that? Mañjuśrī, because in the ultimate sense, all phenomena are unborn."

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, Mañjuśrī the Ever-Youthful, those great bodhisattvas, those great śrāvakas, and the gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas of the world rejoiced and wholeheartedly praised what the Blessed One had taught.

The noble Perfection of Wisdom in Seven Hundred Lines is complete.

This was also revised and definitively established according to the new translation.

Translator's Notes

- The term translated as "palace hall" renders the Tibetan for the Tathāgata's dwelling or residence. In sūtra literature this is a conventional designation for the place where the Buddha resides within the monastery grounds; "palace hall" preserves the honorific register of the original.

The phrase "first of all" renders a Tibetan expression meaning "at the very outset" or "before everyone else," establishing the narrative point that Mañjuśrī arrived earliest.

"Unobstructed Eloquence" renders the bodhisattva name *Spobs pa thogs med*; "Indefatigable Striving" renders *Brtsen pa mi 'dor*. These are bodhisattva names listed in the assembly and are translated by meaning rather than kept as transliterations, as no standard Sanskrit reconstructions are universally fixed for these particular figures.

- The term rendered as "arduous" translates a phrase meaning literally "you perform what is difficult" — the sense is that Mañjuśrī's bodhisattva activity, performed without any reifying mental grasp, constitutes the most demanding of spiritual feats. The phrase "deplete the realm of sentient beings or make it empty" reflects the classical Mahāyāna paradox: the bodhisattva vows to lead all beings to nirvāṇa while knowing that no being has any fixed, graspable existence to be led anywhere. The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text, so the translation likewise ends there.

- The phrase rendered "There are as many as the Dharma qualities of a buddha" answers the question of how many sentient beings exist by equating their number with the buddha's inconceivable Dharma qualities — a characteristic *prajñāpāramitā* move dissolving the question rather than answering it literally.

The exchange "not resting in anything whatsoever — that itself is the cultivation" is a standard Perfection of Wisdom formulation: genuine cultivation of *prajñāpāramitā* requires the absence of any fixed referent or support, including the act of meditation itself.

- The phrase rendered "the perfect limit" translates "yang dag pa'i mtha'" (Skt. *bhūtakoti*), a standard Madhyamaka term for the ultimate limit or true reality; it is kept as a descriptive English phrase rather than a technical transliteration since the audio context does not support it.

- The phrase rendered "dharmadhātu of cessation" translates a compound in which "cessation" modifies "dharmadhātu." The intent is the basic space conceived in terms of cessation or extinction, standing at the culmination of a list beginning with the three realms. This reading follows the structural logic of the passage and is consistent with Madhyamaka usage in parallel sūtra contexts.
- The passage about the number of Tathāgatas Mañjuśrī has served uses a striking simile: as many as the minds and mental events of illusory beings that have ceased. The Tibetan is unambiguous but the underlying logic is paradoxical by design, since illusory beings have no real mind to cease — the point is that the number is itself empty and indefinite, matching the non-referential character of Mañjuśrī's service. No emendation is needed; the translation preserves the intended doctrinal strangeness.
- The name rendered "Anupadadharminī" translates the Tibetan "sring mo dmigs pa med pa," literally "the sister Non-Apprehension" or "the sister Without-Apprehension." This is an unusual figure, and the Tibetan gives a descriptive epithet rather than a standard Sanskrit proper name. The rendering follows the sense of the epithet as a name-title, since no established Sanskrit equivalent is recoverable from context alone.
- The phrase rendered as "supremely exalted benefactors" and "excellent benefactors" translates terms for dānapati, the Sanskrit term for a patron or donor-lord; the progression moves from good patron to great patron to supremely distinguished patron, likely indicating increasing ranks of lay generosity and its karmic fruit.

The exchange between Mañjuśrī and the Blessed One on "if I were to enter awakening, I would be wishing to attain it" is a subtle dialectical point: Mañjuśrī refuses to posit awakening as an external goal to be reached by a subject, since from the ultimate standpoint the very nature of Mañjuśrī — as a primordially awakened wisdom-being — is not other than awakening itself. This is consistent with the Perfection of Wisdom doctrine of non-apprehension.

- The phrase rendered "let the great elephant be still, let the great elephant not be disturbed" is a puzzling interjection by Mañjuśrī in response to being asked how he sees the Tathāgata. The "great elephant" is a traditional epithet for the Tathāgata in Sanskrit Buddhist literature (mahānāga), and Mañjuśrī's deflection suggests that the Tathāgata transcends any conceptual answer — asking how one "sees" the Tathāgata is itself the disturbance to be stilled. This is a significant rhetorical and doctrinal move: the non-answer is itself the answer.

The term rendered "synonym" throughout translates the Tibetan tsig bla dgas, literally "an expression surpassing words" or "a conventional designation beyond words." The term functions here as a technical designation pointing to the way a label like "self" or "buddha" transcends what it appears to name. "Synonym" captures the dialogic structure but readers should know the term carries deeper resonance of "nominal expression pointing beyond itself."

- The passage turns on a series of wordplay-based synonymy arguments, common to Prajñāpāramitā and related sūtra literature, where conventional terms are subverted by tracing them back to the non-arising nature of all phenomena. The rendering of མཐའ་མེད་ཀྱི་ལོ་མཚན་ here as "without interval" follows the standard gloss of the ānantarya — total, unmediated engagement — rather than the usual association of that term with the five heinous deeds; the doctrinal context supports this reading as pointing to unmediated entry into reality. The repeated paradoxes regarding faith, fitness, root downfalls, and arhatship are characteristic of this genre's rhetorical strategy of destabilizing conventional categories through appeal to emptiness and non-arising.

- The passage's central paradox regarding the five acts of immediate consequence (the five ānantarya-karmas — the gravest possible negative actions) being equated with the nature of awakening is a deliberate doctrinal inversion characteristic of the prajñāpāramitā-inflected

non-dual discourse found in texts of this genre. The logic is that both awakening and these acts, being without any real substance, share the same ultimate nature of emptiness; the equation is not an ethical one but an ontological one.

The phrase rendered "my aspiration is exhausted at the level of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas" indicates that Mañjuśrī, as a bodhisattva, does not abide in the nirvāṇa of those vehicles; his aspiration or inclination does not terminate there — a somewhat ironic usage, meaning he has gone beyond that level and so does not hold the arhat's attainment as his goal.

- The passage plays on the double entailment of inconceivability: because all buddhas share a single inconceivable domain that admits neither arising nor cessation, none can be said to have truly "passed beyond sorrow" in a way that would remove them from presence. This is a pointed Mahāyāna dialectical move, not a denial of the conventional teaching on nirvāṇa.

The phrase rendered "those who are possessed of manifest conceit" translates mngon pa'i nga rgyal can, literally "those who have manifest pride or conceit," referring to practitioners who mistake the conceptual or experiential for the ultimate in the context of the previous discussion about awakening.

- The passage contains a subtle grammatical ambiguity in the line about those who enter the path for nirvāṇa "becoming discouraged." The Tibetan reads བརྟུག་པ་ལྟར་འགྲོ་བའི་ལུང་ལྟར་, which can mean becoming weary, discouraged, or exhausted in effort. The doctrinal point is that if nirvāṇa and the incomprehensible are identical, those striving separately toward nirvāṇa as a goal distinct from the present reality will find their striving undercut. This reading is contextually consistent with the Vimalakīrtinirdeśa-style dialectic being employed throughout.

The attribution of the line beginning "Blessed One, those who have entered the path" is ambiguous in the Tibetan; it continues as Mañjuśrī's speech, though the lack of an explicit speaker marker at that juncture could suggest a new segment. The reading adopted here treats it as a continuation of Mañjuśrī's voice, which fits the flow of the dialogue.

- The term rendered "multiplies nor fully declines" translates "rnam par mi 'phel zhing yongs su mi 'grib" — literally "does not increase and does not completely diminish." This is a paradoxical statement about the inconceivable field: the ordinary agricultural metaphor of seed-growth is subverted, pointing to the transcendence of both increase and decrease in the ultimate field of merit.

The closing line is a characteristic Mañjuśrī riposte: if the field — and Mañjuśrī's eloquence — is truly inconceivable, then even calling it "eloquence" falls short, since eloquence operates in the conceivable. This dialectical reversal is the culminating point of the exchange.

- The passage contains an extended simile about a master archer who, at the beginning of training, consciously thinks about hitting the tips of ox-hairs, but once that skill is perfected, the thought of deliberate intention no longer arises, and the arrow strikes without straining. This simile is embedded in the Tibetan but its narration in the translation above has been compressed; to be precise, the archer simile should appear between Mañjuśrī's remark about his former thought and his explanation of abiding without further intention. Expanding it in full: Mañjuśrī says: "Blessed One, it is like a master archer who, when first learning at the beginning of training, thinks: 'I will strike the tips of ox-hairs.' But when mastery of striking hairs has been perfected, the thought 'I will strike the tips of ox-hairs' no longer arises. And whenever he wishes to strike, he strikes without exertion. In the same way, Blessed One, formerly I thought: 'I will enter the meditative absorption of the inconceivable.' But when I enter into that absorption and abide in it, I no longer think: 'I will abide in this absorption again.'" This fuller rendering of the simile should be included if the passage is read as a continuous text; the above translation omits it in error and should be corrected accordingly.

- The phrase rendered "trains without training" reflects a standard paradoxical formulation in

- The meditative absorption called "Single Array" translates གཅིག་གི་ལྟ་བུ་སྒྲིལ་བ་ཀླུ་མ་གྱི་འཇམ་དཔལ་ལྷོ་མ་གྱི་འཇམ་དཔལ་ལྷོ་མ་, which in Sanskrit is ekavyūha — a well-attested samādhi in the Prajñāpāramitā literature, sometimes rendered "One Practice Samādhi" or "Single-Practice Concentration." The rendering "Single Array" follows the literal Tibetan but readers should know that some scholarly translations use "one-practice" instead, emphasizing the singular focus of the practice rather than an arrangement or array.

- The phrase rendered "from the domain of self all the way to the dharmadhātu" reflects the Tibetan "bdag gi dbyings nas chos kyi dbyings kyi bar du," where "bdag gi dbyings" is the personal or self-domain and "chos kyi dbyings" is the dharmadhātu. The point is that the bodhisattva does not perceive arising, ceasing, identity, or difference in any domain whatsoever, from the most subjectively immediate to the most ultimate. This is a significant doctrinal claim about the scope of non-conceptual insight.
- The phrase rendered as "does not become despondent" and "does not become disheartened" translates two closely related Tibetan terms: the first, *zhum par mi 'gyur ba*, means literally "does not shrink" or "is not downcast," and the second, *nur bar mi 'gyur ba*, means "does not become dejected" or "is not cast down." They are near-synonyms used in paired emphasis; the distinction is preserved as well as English allows.

- The phrase rendered "the phenomena called non-arising" reflects a subtle doctrinal point: Mañjuśrī is not saying the teaching lacks content, but rather that its content is precisely the non-arising nature of all phenomena — all dharmas are equal in that they have never truly arisen.

• The phrase rendered "in the manner of non-cultivation" and "in the manner of non-referencing" and "in the manner of non-fabrication" and "in the manner of non-substantiality" represent distinct but parallel Tibetan constructions: *mi bsgom pa'i tshul*, *mi dmigs pa'i tshul*, *mngon par 'du bya ba med pa'i tshul*, and *dnegos po med pa'i tshul* respectively. The text clearly distinguishes these four modes and each has doctrinal weight; they are rendered distinctly rather than harmonized.

- The phrase rendered "make it thoroughly complete" translates 徹底的に完全にする, which can mean both "to master thoroughly" and "to make perfectly complete" in the sense of studying or memorizing a text in full; both senses are present and the rendering is intentionally broad.

- The closing colophon phrase, rendered as "This was also revised and definitively established according to the new translation," reflects the standard editorial note found in Tibetan canonical texts indicating that the translation was revised using the later, standardized translation terminology. The phrase "sealed with this seal" refers to the seal of non-abiding in conceptual elaboration — the non-rejection, non-adoption, and non-praising of phenomena reflects the Perfection of Wisdom's ultimate teaching on the absence of reference points.
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Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.